

Coverstory HOMOSEXUALITY

ually more inventive. Video is the most popular format with the highest patrons in Hyderabad (68 per cent) followed by Kolkata (59 per cent). It's interesting to note that one out of every 25 women who watch pornography admitted to having made their own porn videos. Therefore, not only are women watching porn, they are also participating in its production. However, it should not be assumed that the videos are being produced for public circulation but possibly as part of sexual play in intimate spaces. Today, home videos permeate all parts of people's lives and the erotic space is no exception. The Internet sexual adventures of Savita Bhabhi, an illustrated porn series, could qualify as "home porn".

Historically, the pornography debate has been fraught. The traditional moralists and some feminist groups (albeit for very different reasons) have opposed pornography. The traditional moralists view it as a preoccupation with sex that is not related to the purpose of sex, which is reproduction. They view pornography (and all sex outside marriage) as a threat to traditional family values. The feminist view of pornography has a contentious history in the West. The anti-pornography feminists known as the "radical feminists" demand censorship of all pornography because it is believed to encourage a culture of rape and violence against women. In the 1980s and '90s, this position found its strongest supporters in Catherine MacKinnon and Andrea Dworkin whose crusade for censorship took inspiration from slogans like "pornography is the theory and rape is the practice".

The anti-censorship feminist position, whose politics I share, draws attention to the difference between sexist speech and sexually explicit speech. All sexually explicit speech is not sexist just as all sexist speech is not sexual. Therefore, it is the sexism in the genre that has to be fought and not the genre itself. Anti-censorship feminists repeatedly draw attention to the overwhelming data that fails to show causal links between pornography and violence including those used by radical feminists to support their position. To this end, they quote an important 1987 study which reads: "Should harsher penalties be levelled against persons who traffic in pornography? We do not believe so. Rather, it is our opinion that the most prudent course of action would be development of educational programmes that would teach viewers to be critical consumers of the media."

In India, pornography is common but usually

Do you ever fantasise about having a homosexual experience?

YES 15

NO 85

Male 22, Female 8

Male 78, Female 92

All figures in per cent

One out of five men has fantasised about a same sex relationship at some point in his life.

SWINGING BOTH WAYS

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PER CENT WOMEN IN KOLKATA DECLARED THEY WERE BISEXUAL, THE HIGHEST IN THE COUNTRY.